When Your Family Falls Apart

By Nova Venerable

INTRODUCTION

By all accounts Nova Venerable was a troubled child. Once a student at Oak Park/River Forest High School, Illinois, she described her high-school self in this way, "I was really angry all the time, I used to try to fight people every day, I used to yell at people, choke people, stab at people with pencils."

But poetry (and speech competitions) gave her a constructive outlet -- a way to express herself and feel rewarded for it. Her poems about her addicted father and her younger brother Cody are raw, honest and heart-breaking.

When Your Family Falls Apart by Nova Venerable

Apartment on Austin

There are always sirens outside your place.
Your condo always seemed to lean to the left,
the cement windows rusted like overused water pipes.
We lived on the first floor.
The mango skinned buzzer never worked.
A window in the door was cracked.
Broken into on Austin, stole everything but your big

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screen TV and your furniture
Because everyone with a grudge knew that
You worked nights at Joliet and days at Chicago Public Schools
Never enough time to sleep.
Our condo door was tainted white,
like a three year old sock washed every week,
the walls were the 49ers,
the carpet was rough,
like tangled hair,
everything you had no room for
piled on to shelves like children.
It smelled like alcohol, bad food and body odor mixed like margaritas.
You would always ask me to make your drinks,
Measure liquid with the width of my nine year old fingers:
Four fingers sangria,
two gin,
two tonic,
and one lemon juice.
Sometimes I remembered I would wake up,
And you would be standing in the doorway,
Smiling at us while we slept.
I would wrap my arms around your sunken stomach

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Like tissue paper you would kiss my forehead, lay me back down,
Tie me in bows around my blankets
Because momma moved out and wasn't around to do it no more.
By the time I was 10,
I was your wife,
your mother,
your best friend,
your sister,
and you were bitter.
I would feed you chicken soup when you were sick,
kiss your forehead to see how bad your fever was.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nova Venerable
DVD: Louder Than a Bomb
DVD available at Amazon.com
ASIN: B006UTDG42
Publisher: Virgil Films
Date (Month/Year): March 20, 2012
On-line Video at
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FZMpePbF454

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Phone Wires

Prison guards maced my father when I was 12.
He fell asleep on his back that night,
gas braiding down his throat
like rain on power lines
I wonder if he remembers
he woke up screaming for me
that I walked him to the bathroom,
cleaned his eyes with cold water
and put him back to bed.

My mother used to tell me
that my father was disgusting
that I didn't have to see him if I
didn't want to.
"Tell the cops he's physically, emotionally
and psychologically abusive"
like I knew what that meant
when I was 11.

I would wake my father up every night
at 9:00 and braid his hair.
Over, Under, Over, Under
The grease seeped
from his scalp and kept

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his dandruff suffocating
under my fingernails.
"Nova girl, you're gonna come see me more right?
You're gonna tell the judge that you wanna see me just
as much as your mother?"
His eyes sagged,
a job,
pent up under each one.

"Nova, just tell him you don't wanna see him anymore."
My mother dialed his number
and stayed on the line,
made sure that I left my father
hung up on other end of chords,
ending my father and I like phone calls.
She taught me to break my father's heart
with wires,
My Baba and I haven't spoken since I was 12.

My father's left eye sagged more than his right,
night time prison guard stretched
out his face.
He risked his life every day for his children
every time he drove to Joliet.
kept teaching at Chicago Public Schools

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His right eye was darker,
cramped in the wrinkles of his skin,
promised he would teach
Them like he did his children.
Over, Under, Over, Under

After I hung up the phone
mom asked me
if it was really
all that hard
to break my father's heart
and at 17 I can finally answer her question.

I can tell her
I know why our relationship is choking
I left father for mother
and I wake up cold,
dreaming about my Baba
waiting to tell him that I have his eyes.
Want to know if he wonders which college his baby girl
is going to.
I can tell her that I hate talking on the phone now
I wish I could erase calls from five years ago
so I wouldn't have liked when I told my father
"Yes, Daddy, I'm gonna come see you more.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nova Venerable
Book: Learn Then Burn (Pg 57)
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Cody

My youngest brother was born
with my grandfather's nose
round like spools of thread,
my father's eyes and
my mother's genes.

He is 12 years old now and
I watch him play
Hungry Hungry Hippos,
see his body jitters
like a wind up toy
and he screams like a happy crow
when he asks me to play with him.

He tries to learn the words
to the Scooby-doo song,
repeats the phrases my mother
and I say, and when I see him,
I wonder how could God know that
Diabetes peels 27 years of life
like dead skin.
Yet he still allows my brother
to have his fingers pricked
every day.

Why is it when I look
at him, I can see every needle
we've ever had to stick
his arms, legs, or stomach with
to keep him alive.
Sometimes five shots a day
isn't enough to fight juvenile diabetes.

I think

How could God bless him
with seizures and autism.
Why every time we rush him to the hospital
it could be my last day watching
him rewind on-demand
until his lips can curve
to form words

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that aren't even his because my mother
gave him a broken X chromosome.

Today,
I will smile
As he learns to brush his teeth for the first time
or obsesses over his red pants and shirts,
I will laugh as he tries to learn sign language
to make up for tongue lost in Fragile-X
Syndrome
and I will accept his fake kisses
like disorders.

But I can't help but wonder
Can his brain still hold the times
I meshed his food up when he was 8
or changed his diapers at 7.

Will he miss me
when I am not there to run my fingers
through his hair like Pink Oil
Over, Under, Over, Under
when he wakes up from
ear tube surgeries or seizures.

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Will he remember
how he slept in my bed every night
after mama left,
and I held him like an extra pillow.
Or when my arms were his restraints
when daddy said put him in middle
without seatbelt so he would be the
first to die in car accident.
Can he know how he found
a mother in big sister?

For now,
I will pray for him every night
that his kidneys will stop trying to fail on us,
that his blood sugar won't send him into
a coma.
I hope
that he won't grow accustomed
to not pronouncing my name
when I go away to college,
and I pray I pray that his seizures
won't kill him before his diabetes does.
Over, Under, Over, Under

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From Apartment on Austin

[Baba] . . . I'm 17 now,
and we don't even talk.
And sometimes I wish I could tell you
how much I miss you.
How I want to wrap my arms around
your sunken stomach like tissue paper.
That I love you,
and I wish you were here to be my Papa G again.
So you would know that I have a boyfriend
that loves me more than you ever use to.
But I guess you're too busy rusting,
like cement windows,
to notice that your baby girl is a woman.
Over, Under, Over, Under

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UPDATE: *In 2020, the NSDA Board of Directors voted to pilot new rules regarding what sources for material may be used in Interpretation events, including removal of the requirement that digital sources must be found on the Approved Websites List.* ***Students are no longer required to use only digital sources found on this list.***

This change may or may not impact specific regional or state tournaments. Please check requirements for publication for your tournament before performing this poetry selection.

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